

work to have survived is the dramatic recitative known as the “Lamento d’Arianna.”



FRONTISPIECE OF *L'ORFEO*

Monteverdi's *L'Orfeo* is one of the world's first operas. This frontispiece is from a 1609 edition, published two years after the work was written.

Troubled times

Although Monteverdi was at the peak of his musical powers, his life had entered a difficult phase. The death of his wife after a painful illness in September 1607 left him grief-stricken and solely responsible for three children. Forced into overwork on